Potty Training Is Not a Milestone. It's a Negotiation With a Tiny Terrorist.

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Our daughter was two years and four months old, and according to every parenting book, article, and well-meaning stranger, she was “ready.” She was not ready. She looked the potty in the eye and chose the diaper every single time, with the confidence of a person who had weighed both options carefully.

We started with the famous three-day method. You know the one: pants off, potty everywhere, juice boxes flowing, no leaving the house. Day one, she peed on the rug six times and sat on the potty zero times. Day two, she learned to hold it until exactly the moment we looked away. Day three, my wife and I sat on the kitchen floor and ate crackers in silence while our daughter, fully naked, pointed at the potty and said “no thank you.” It was the most polite rejection I’d ever received, and it broke us.

Then came the sticker chart phase. A chart, bright stickers, a prize at the end. She loved the stickers. She peeled them off the chart and stuck them to the dog. The dog did not complain. The chart remained empty.

Then the bribery phase, which I am not proud of: one chocolate chip per successful potty visit. She figured out the system within a day — she’d sit on the potty, produce nothing, and demand the chip with her hand out. I was running a protection racket for an empty potty. I was being played by a two-year-old and she knew it.

Here’s what actually worked: we stopped. All of it. The potty went back in the corner of the bathroom, no ceremony, no announcement. We changed diapers without commentary. For two months, nobody said the word “potty” in our house unless she said it first. It felt like giving up. It was the best parenting decision we made that year.

Three weeks after we quit, she walked into the bathroom, used the potty, and came out like it was the most ordinary thing in the world. Because to her, by then, it was. The pressure was gone, so the resistance was gone. She trained herself in about ten days. No chart. No chips. The dog kept

the stickers.

I'm not saying readiness is a myth — some kids genuinely are ready at two, and good for them. What I'm saying is that *our* daughter wasn't, and all the methods in the world couldn't change the timeline. The signs were there the whole time: she hid to poop (a classic readiness sign we ignored), she hated being wet (another one), and she could pull her pants down. She had the equipment. She just didn't have the willingness, and willingness isn't something you can schedule.

If you're in the trenches right now, here's the only advice I'll stand behind: stop comparing. The kid at the playground who trained at eighteen months has nothing to do with your kid. Your pediatrician's chart has an average, not a deadline. And if the method is making everyone in the house miserable — you, your partner, the kid — it's allowed to not work. Put the potty in the corner, take a month off, and try again when it doesn't feel like a war.

The war ended for us the day we surrendered. Funny how that works.